lost MP to the BJP because of defections, the Congress has to unite behind leaders in these states if it has to return to power. It will, however, be no guarantee for success in the Lok Sabha, for despite winning these states in 2018, the Congress occupies only one out of the 91 seats these states account for.

There is no departure thus from a trend long established. When voters have to choose between the Congress and BJP in assembly polls, they make choices based on local issues, performance and leadership. In the general election, however, when the choice is between Modi and Rahul Gandhi, the battle becomes unidimensional. In 110 seats—across Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Rajasthan, Gujarat, MP, Haryana and Chhattisgarh—the Congress boasts one MP. How it does in these 110 seats will indicate how much mileage Rahul Gandhi's Bharat Jodo Yatra, essentially a rebranding exercise for the Congress scion, has been able to generate, never mind the sound and fury around it. The party's performance in these seats will determine the collective strength of the Opposition.

The Congress's challenges come not just from the BJP but also from newer players such as AAP, who are emerging in terrains where the grand old party still has visible organisational presence. Many observers in fact claim that AAP's entry in states such as Goa, Uttarakhand and Gujarat has helped the BJP by splitting the anti-BJP vote. In Gujarat too, several Congress leaders hold AAP responsible for cutting into their votes and giving the BJP a historic mandate.

THE HIMACHAL WIN HIGHLIGHTS THAT CONGRESS CAN COUNTER THE MODI MAGIC IN STATES WHERE IT STILL HAS AN ORGANISATION AND THERE'S NO STRONG THIRD PARTY

However, not everyone in the party buys this argument. Whether AAP cuts into the Congress vote bank or not, the Arvind Kejriwal-led party has its own challenges, particularly in states where the BJP local unit is strong. Certainly, the party is buoyed by its recent victory in the Delhi municipal polls, and in Punjab earlier this year. But when it comes to the Lok Sabha, it faces the same syndrome as the Congress does against Modi. Despite its grip over Delhi for nearly 10 years, it failed to win even a single Lok Sabha seat in the previous two Lok Sabha elections. In the Modi vs Kejriwal battle, the former still enjoys the edge in the Lok Sabha. Also, as the Gujarat assembly polls have shown, Kejriwal will have to wait for some more time and hope that Modi's influence wanes by the time he is ready to prove himself a truly national leader.

While Kejriwal seems pretty secure in his home turf, other non-Congress leaders are having to focus on protecting theirs. In West Bengal, the Mamata Banerjee-led TMC survived a scare in the Lok Sabha when the BJP won 18 out of the 42 seats in 2019. Mercifully, it had no bearing on the assembly election last year, which the West Bengal chief minister swept, despite the many defections and the BJP unleashing its heaviest electoral artillery and financial might. In neighbouring Odisha, the Naveen Patnaik-led Biju Janata Dal has enjoyed an unchallenged run for the past two decades, but had to cede some ground to the BJP in 2019, when the saffron brigade cornered eights of the state's 21 seats. With Patnaik getting on in years and no clear line of succession in the BJD, the BJP is hoping to gain from the dissension within the BJD. Patnaik himself is in no mood to relent, counter punching every move of the BJP. Another big battleground will be Maharashtra, with its 48 parliamentary seats. The BJP lost its long-time ally Shiv Sena to the Congress and Nationalist Congress Party. Subsequently, though, it has been successful in splitting the Sena and is hoping that the weakened force will find its influence waning that may make it difficult to stitch an effective coalition like the Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi.

The BJP also remains on pretty solid ground in Uttar Pradesh. With a strong and charismatic chief minister in Yogi Adityanath, the party's double-engine pitch gives it a decisive edge. Regional stalwarts such as Akhilesh Yadav of SP and Mayawati of BSP did combine their forces in 2019, but failed to shake the BJP's phenomenal hold in the state. The BJP won 62 out of 80 seats—the largest in the Lok Sabha—on its own, with the SP-BSP combine winning only 15 and the other parties taking the remaining.



ANI

DAMP SQUIB
Congress leader Rahul Gandhi and (right) AAP chief Arvind Kejriwal campaign ahead of the Gujarat polls